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Buying State Power: How Elite-Led Propaganda Through Advertising Mechanisms is Connected to Democratic Weakening in Four Countries

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ABSTRACT

Top-down information control through strategic executions of propaganda campaigns does not only occur in autocratic countries, as we show here, political elites and allies in weakening democracies engage in information manipulation and control tactics to attack existing pillars of democracy, such as the independent press and free and fair elections. We expand upon the scholarship of “competitive authoritarianism” by focusing on these actors’ resource weaponization and degrees of capture of both traditional and digital advertising mechanisms to spread propaganda in order to bolster and centralize their political power. To do so, we engage in an international comparative study of four countries considered competitive authoritarian regimes: Bolivia, Hungary, Tunisia, and Turkey. Thematic analysis of data collected in 60 in-depth interviews with media and political experts indicates that these political elites and their allies wield advertising resources as a means to spread pro-government propaganda and exact informational control in coordinated efforts across digital and traditional media realms. In the case studies, we examine here, we argue that actors use advertising to manipulate information spaces with the anti-democratic aim of attacking critical and dissenting voices to suppress political plurality and centralize a budding authoritative power.

KEYWORDS

Advertising; propaganda; democratic weakening; competitive authoritarianism; media capture

Introduction

Top-down control of information environments is typical of fully authoritarian governments. However, the control of information environments is also prevalent in weakening democracies that have not yet crossed over into complete authoritarianism (Diamond, 2022; Trauthig et al., 2023). ¹In this article, we compare how propaganda is being spread through political advertising (both traditional and digital) by actors in four countries that are currently classified as regimes of “competitive authoritarianism” (Levitsky & Way, 2020): Bolivia, Hungary, Tunisia, and Turkey (Esen & Gumuscu, 2025; Riaz & Rana, 2024; Rupnik, 2022; Yerkes & Henneberg, 2024).

This study answers the call from Freelon and Wells (2020) to conduct more rigorous, empirical studies of propaganda and disinformation as a “threat” to “healthy democratic

practice,” and the more recent call from Semetko and Sundar (2024) for international comparative work examining the effects of digital political misinformation during societal crises. We specifically examine how in these four countries, political elites and their allies strategically weaken democratic institutions and processes by abusing advertising while maintaining the illusion that they support democratic practices. We show how these actors spread political propaganda: they use advertising money as a cudgel, leveraging the threat posed by social media and digital media’s near-monopoly of the advertising market to at least partially capture traditional media, such as print newspapers and television. We thereby connect existing research on media capture and digital advertising within the context of state-led democratic weakening.

We ground the themes of our qualitative analysis in recognized state-led democratic weakening tactics used by political elites and their allies in weakening democracies (Cirone & Hobbs, 2023; Woolley & Howard, 2018). By “political elites” we mean figures in current or former positions of political power who have significant influence within the political ecosystem (i.e. current or former President, Prime Minister, Member of Parliament, etc.). By allies, we mean both economic allies (e.g., business leaders, owners of media organizations) and political allies (e.g., hired propagandists, ideological supporters).

The four countries we examine have several things in common. First, their media and propagandistic infrastructures were formed by a legacy of colonialism and revolution (Coşkun, 2023; Foroudi, 2019; Kovács et al., 2021; McKay & Colque, 2021). Second, all four are currently categorized as competitive authoritarian regimes experiencing state-led democratic weakening; these countries’ elected political leaders have recently adopted undemocratic tactics in political communication (Lim & Bradshaw, 2023; Moravec & Folk, 2023; Reuters, 2022; Zaghoudi, 2023), and their independent media landscapes are waning as their pro-government media outlets are growing (Freedom House, 2024a, 2024b, 2024c, 2024d). (See Appendix A for more detailed information about how these countries were selected.)

We conduct 60 qualitative in-depth interviews² with journalists, civil society activists, media analysts and experts, and government workers³ to ask how these political elites and allies use information manipulation and control tactics within traditional and now, digital advertising mechanisms to undermine democratic pillars (such as plurality of political voices within an independent press and greater marketplace of ideas). Data collected in interviews indicate that in these countries, political elites and allies manipulate advertising resources to accrue partisan favor and crush-independent media voices, weakening the democratic pillar of the free press. These actors weaponize traditional and social media advertising as a source of information control, coordinating propaganda, disinformation, and harassment campaigns to create an advertising ecosystem dominated by pro-government messaging, with opposing voices drowned out. These actors weaponize their considerable advertising budgets to manipulate domestic information ecosystems for anti-democratic purposes: they seek to weaken critical media, to reduce the plurality of political voices that are heard, to undermine devices of political participation, and to silence opposition. This robust qualitative study, using an international comparative approach, contributes empirical complexity, nuance, and variation to the existing literature on propaganda and advertising, showing how these domains work together to weaken the pillars of democracy in vulnerable countries.

Literature Review

State-Led Democratic Weakening

All four countries in our study—Bolivia, Hungary, Tunisia, and Turkey—are experiencing a strategic state-led attack on democratic institutions and activities. An idealistic, functioning democracy typically includes the following democratic pillars: free and fair elections, protection of civil liberties and elected officials’ capacity to govern, and an “even playing field between government and opposition” (Levitsky & Way, 2002, p. 53). In authoritarian regimes, these components are virtually absent; in *competitive* authoritarian regimes, these democratic pillars are seen as the primary vehicle to “obtaining and exercising political authority,” but are frequently violated by political authorities, who seek primarily to satisfy the “minimum standards for democracy” (Levitsky & Way, 2002, p. 52).

In this study, we lean on Levitsky and Way’s (2002) framework of media contestation within competitive authoritarian countries. In this framework, independent media and critical speech exist and can even be quite influential, for government suppression is executed through “subtle mechanisms” (p. 58) rather than full authoritarianism’s outright censorship and direct violence against journalists. As we show here, these subtle mechanisms include the “selective” distribution of advertising contracts and the manipulation of financial incentives/disincentives (Besley & Prat, 2006).

Our conceptualization of how these competitive authoritarian regimes erode democratic pillars follows previous literature examining how political authorities (rather than citizens and voters; Carothers & Hartnett, 2024) create democratic regression (Gandhi, 2019). In this study, we focus upon how authoritative figures erode democratic pillars through subtle information control, all the while keeping up the pretense of democratic and political legitimacy, “surgically” creating and wielding information control over the media landscape (Guriev & Treisman, 2019; Trauthig et al., 2023). This allows them to push propaganda, sustain surveillance, and enact repressive tactics to stifle the opposition while retaining plausible deniability about the status of their countries’ democracies. In this study, we adopt Woolley’s (2023) definition of propaganda as “the use of politically biased information in considered attempts to manipulate or influence the opinions and actions of individuals and, more broadly, society” (p. 4). We also note that these propaganda campaigns can include false information (or half-truths) and be deployed using deceitful tactics (i.e. deception of messenger or goal or coercion using threat or force) (Woolley, 2023; Ellul, 1965).

Whether propaganda is essential for or completely juxtaposed to functioning democracies is a rich point of contention. Early scholars believed that appointed political and media elites spreading propaganda—or as Lippmann (1922) called a manipulated construction of a “manufacture of consent” for publics’ worldviews—was ultimately beneficial for everyday citizens. The fabric of a democratic society could be sustained, argued Lippmann (1922) and Bernays (1928), as elites acted as shepherds guiding masses into their “correct” version of reality. We adopt a scholarship which illustrates propagandists’ construction of a worldview that lies beyond the confines of politics and envelops all aspects of life—education, culture, economics, literature and more (Bernays, 1928; Cheek, 1998; Kenez, 1985; Lippmann, 1922). In our case, propagandists embed within and control information ecosystems in a varied manner.

However, this study adopts a contrasting scholarly angle compared to Lippmann (1922) and Bernays (1928) elite-led “democratic” propaganda. Supported by Ellul (1965) and

Kenez (1985), we argue that the anti-democratic trouble lies with the particular method (i.e. deception, coercion) and political aim (i.e. quelling dissent, centralizing political power) of propaganda. To this extent, Ellul (1965) argued that propaganda may be inevitable across democratic and authoritarian societies, but it is still inherently anti-democratic; it thwarts rather than encourages citizen deliberation. Critical for this study, Ellul (1965) argued that as societies continue to modernize technology, so will societies continue to modernize propaganda (that continually undermines democracy).

Historically, the manifestation of propaganda in democratic or authoritarian states was seen as differing; democratic leaders were forced to disguise propaganda as subtle and natural within purposefully designed competitive and pluralistic information ecosystems, while authoritarian actors relied on powerful, centralized information spheres to overtly suppress critical voices in a highly systemic way (Cheek, 1998; Ellul, 1965; Kenez, 1985). However, and as this study notes, the rise of competitive authoritarian regimes results in the mixed levels of elite-controlled information ecosystems where both overt and subtle propagandistic techniques can occur.

Given evolving traditional and digital information environments, propagandistic actors within these semi-democratic systems must embed their messaging into an adaptable information vehicle that can consistently reach people over time (Cheek, 1998; Ellul, 1965; Kenez, 1985). To do so, competitive authoritarian regimes slowly gain control of the information landscape using their financial resources to manipulate media advertising in order to deploy information control campaigns, disseminating propaganda (Woolley, 2023) and disinformation (the strategic dissemination of false information designed for a particular gain [i.e. political, financial] and to intentionally cause harm [i.e. marginalization] (Freelon & Wells, 2020; Prochaska et al., 2023)); staging trolling, harassment, and smear campaigns to confuse, discourage, suppress, and scare critical voices (Woolley, 2023; Kenez, 1985); and “flooding” the media zone—filling it with so much propaganda that citizens are left confused and hopeless, reducing their motivation to vote (Cirone & Hobbs, 2023). These information control campaigns deceive citizens and ultimately undermine free and fair elections, tilting the playing field to favor incumbent parties (Levitsky & Way, 2002). They also erode the democratic civil liberties of freedom of speech and the press by systematically stifling dissent (Dahl, 1971; Hollyer et al., 2011). We see these campaigns as what Bakir et al. (2019) call “non-consensual organized persuasion communication” (OPC) campaigns, which combine public relations, advertising, strategic communications, propaganda, influence and psychological operations to create “forms of persuasion of deception, incentivization and coercion.”

Advertising Resources and Mechanisms

We view the political advertising OPCs in these four countries as forms of state-led media capture. Early theories of media capture argued that states gain undue political control over the media through economic regulations (Besley & Prat, 2006); modern theories view media as having been captured when governments and their political or economic allies wield power over “regulation, public/state media, state financial resources, and the private media sector” to “manipulate” the methods, output, and reception of the news media to fit their political goals (Dragomir, 2024, p. 163). This modern conceptualization of media capture highlights the role of the private sector—especially important for our argument about

competitive authoritarian regimes, which are not yet at the point of total state ownership or censorship of the media (Dragomir & Aslama Horowitz, 2021; Levitsky & Way, 2020). But as Besley and Prat (2006) point out, *all* forms and levels of media capture thwart the independence of journalism—a key democratic pillar (Kovach & Rosenstiel, 2021) that is frequently attacked by competitive authoritarian regimes (Levitsky & Way, 2002, 2010). Even when governments and their allies are not engaging in outright censorship through direct ownership of a media company (e.g., an imposed editorial censorship that exerts full control over produced content), they still engage in what Stiglitz (2017) calls “cognitive capture.” According to Stiglitz (2017), partially captured media of this type does not perform its watchdog function as the “fourth estate,” instead serving as “little more than a reflection” of the “conventional wisdom” of society (p. 14). In other words, cognitively captured media perpetuates (rather than engages critically with) the political status quo.

In the countries we study, a key driver of media capture is political elites’ and their allies’ weaponizing of the advertising revenue that keeps modern media afloat (Dragomir & Aslama Horowitz, 2021). The traditional media revenue model, which relies heavily on advertising and reader subscriptions, is susceptible to governments’ “selective allocation of advertising,” which can be used to suppress independent journalism (Yanatma, 2021) and bolster government-friendly outlets (Kerpel, 2017). Often, political advertising contracts, especially electoral-season contracts, bring in enough revenue to keep media outlets afloat the rest of the year (Selvik & Høigilt, 2023). The need for this revenue can functionally limit media organizations’ autonomy over their advertising operations—and, in turn, shape their reporting. Independent journalism is also currently under intense financial pressure from social media platforms, which have become heavyweights in the digital news and advertising sector (Dragomir, 2024)—a phenomenon that Nechushtai (2018) refers to as “infrastructural capture.” Social platforms are now “crucial” dependencies for media organizations, which rely heavily on social media for the advertising revenue that enables them to “sustainably” survive (Nechushtai, 2018, p. 1043)—a vulnerability that is weaponized by political elites and allies.

Social media advertising offers incentives and disincentives for political elites and allies, both within and outside of competitive authoritarian regimes. Political actors choose to engage with platforms’ “digital architecture” to fully take advantage of social media’s communicative benefits, including the feature of advertising (Bossetta, 2018). For example, social media offers advertising metrics that show exactly who engages with what specific content, allowing politicians and parties to better understand their audiences (Kreiss et al., 2018). Platforms’ micro-targeting capabilities allow politicians to digitally reach niche audiences across demographics, interests, location, and more (Barbu, 2014). Platforms incentivize political actors to continue investing in its advertising functions through offering these special data and targeting privileges (Vaidhyanathan, 2022). Social media platforms’ novel data-driven opportunities also allow both “sanctioned” and “shadow” political actors to engage in influence campaigns (Udupa, 2024), for many platforms offer easy turnkey instructions for advertisers, allowing both sophisticated political mavericks and political newcomers to leverage their targeting tools (ibid).

However, political advertising on social media does have its drawbacks. First, it tends to replicate the power imbalances that exist offline, including political power imbalances (Chu et al., 2024). Smaller political parties with slighter budgets struggle to compete with dominant political forces (Chu et al., 2024, p. 303). Second, although social media

advertising allows political actors to directly communicate with audiences cheaply and at scale (Fowler et al., 2021), the *effectiveness* of this advertising—its translation to votes or changes in attitudes—is not clear. As Dommett and Power (2019) note, there simply is not enough transparency from either platforms or governments to understand the effects of political advertising campaigns on social media; data given through ad libraries are sparse and incomplete (Pershan & Lesplingart, 2024).

Setting aside the question of the effects of political social media ads on voters, this study focuses upon the actions and potential motivations of political elites and allies who use these ads: for these groups, social media advertising is a channel of information control and manipulation that allows them to maintain outward appearances of democratic upkeep and political legitimacy. As we show, political actors in competitive authoritarian regimes strategically dominate both traditional and digital advertising channels year-round. We interrogate the potential political consequences of this information control, asking: (RQ1) *How have political elites and their allies utilized state resources for political advertising?* (RQ2) *How have the mechanisms of political capture in traditional media advertising been adapted and extended to digital media advertising?* Lastly, we ask (RQ3) *How do political advertising practices by elites and their allies undermine key democratic pillars (such as transparency and plurality of political voices)?*

Research Design

Data Collection

We approach these research questions through a qualitative comparative study of four countries characterized in the scholarly literature as democracies weakening into competitive authoritarian regimes: Bolivia, Hungary, Tunisia, and Turkey Esen and Gumuscu (2025); Riaz and Rana (2024); Rupnik (2022); Yerkes and Henneberg (2024). (For more information on case selection, see [Appendix A](#).) These countries were chosen because of their weakening independent media landscapes, which enable propaganda to spread through both traditional and digital media (Freedom House, 2024a, 2024b, 2024c, 2024d). In addition, across these four countries, political elites and allies deployed laws purportedly to combat “fake news” that in fact curb freedom of speech and expression (Article19, 2023, p. 19; Lim & Bradshaw, 2023; Moravec & Folk, 2023; Zaghdoudi, 2023).

These countries all also have histories of (and lingering infrastructural and societal impacts from) colonialism and the subsequent revolution and independence movements (Coşkun, 2023; Crabtree, 2017; Kovács et al., 2021; Yerkes & Alhomoud, 2022). In addition, in all four countries, notable elections over the last two decades were linked to the weakening of democratic institutions: (1) in Hungary, the 2010 election of Fidesz Prime Minister Viktor Orbán weakened the judicial system (European Parliament, 2022) and reduced the political plurality expressed in media Political Capital (2022); (2) in Bolivia, Evo Morales (2006–2019) and his Movimiento al Socialismo (MAS) party (2020–present) have persistently posed legal challenges to presidential term limits (Doyle, 2019) and escalated the polarization along ethnic lines, leading to an increase in violence (Global Centre for Pluralism, 2021), (3) in Turkey, since President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan was elected in 2014, government critics have been targeted and detained (Kirby, 2023); and (4) in Tunisia, since

President Kais Saied was elected in 2019 (and subsequently grabbed additional power in 2021), he has begun to imprison his political challengers (Yerkes & Alhomoud, 2022).

We conducted 60 approximately hour-long in-depth and semi-structured interviews over Zoom between November 2023 and August 2024. We interviewed media professionals, government workers, members of parliament, digital rights activists, and policy and political analysts across Bolivia (16), Hungary (16), Tunisia (11),⁴ and Turkey (17). Early round interviewees were chosen because of their expertise in their country's media, political, and technological landscapes; later interviewees were approached via snowball sampling based on recommendations from previous interviews (Noy, 2008). We primarily approached political and media experts and analysts who could speak to the experiences of the independent press in their respective countries. This strategy aligns with the paper's theoretical framework that examines how competitive authoritarian regimes attack freedom of expression and use media capture as a tactic for information manipulation and control⁵ (See [Appendix B Table B1](#) for Interviewee Details). Interviewees were asked about the state of their country's media landscape—including traditional and digital media—and the nature of political interventions, including changes in media independence and the role of government oversight. We also inquired about how government or political actors use advertising resources to spread their messaging. Furthermore, questions addressed the potential democratic implications of government advertising, based on interviewees' responses (See [Appendix B Table B2](#) for Expanded Interview Questionnaire).⁶

Interviews concluded when we reached sample sizes comparable to those in other qualitative research studies investigating the flow of political information, including partisan and propagandistic messaging (Van Duyn, 2024; Wang, 2024); at this time, we also began to receive repeated similar responses, reflecting a saturation point. All interviewees gave informed verbal consent, were asked and agreed to audio and/or video recordings and were offered the option to choose anonymity. In accordance with IRB⁷ several pseudonyms are used for anonymous sources within the paper's findings.

Data Analysis

To analyze the interview data, we used qualitative thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2006; Charmaz, 2006). Thematic analysis supports theoretical development grounded in data, specifically inductive research where theoretical analysis and development stems from collected data (Rose, 1954). For each interview, the research team created interview memos that included the interviewee's professional background, their choice of anonymization, any highlighted notes and observations, and selected relevant quotes from interviewees. These interview memos were systematically and iteratively compared to one another to develop and apply a set of categorical codes across all memos. Subsequently, these codes were consolidated into a set of overarching themes that cut across all interview data, and these themes support the development of a theoretical argument. Codes and themes were initially created by the first author and subsequently reexamined and revised by the research team to assure that the themes were high quality and consistent, in accordance with the objectives of our research questions. While our goal was to find commonalities between the different country case studies to discern overarching trends, the thematic analysis also shed light on interesting nuances that exist *within* these overarching commonalities, and we also explore these in this study. We recognize the

subjectivity within researcher-led coding (Charmaz, 2006), but it remains the best way to holistically analyze large interview datasets without removing complexity, nuance, and contradiction from findings.

Findings

Traditional Media and Advertisement Resources

Our interviewees' responses aligned with the model put forth by Dragomir (2024) and Stiglitz (2017), which argues that governments achieve media capture by weaponizing financial incentives/disincentives across public and private media. Interviewees felt that advertising revenue from government contracts and government-friendly corporations was a means of political information control over both state-owned and state-captured media outlets as well as independent media landscapes, including television, radio, print and online news. According to Bolivian journalist Isabel, in traditional media, political actors' decisions to award or withdraw advertising contracts with media outlets were viewed as political rewards or punishments; in her words, these "taxes and audits . . . and boycott of advertisement" are meant to force media organizations to "fail" or be "unsustainable."

According to our interviewees, political elites both support "friendly" media outlets and undermine critical ones, encouraging governmental and corporate advertisers to withdraw ads from independent and critical sources—a finding also observed by Yanatma (2021). According to Hungarian journalist Daniel, journalists from independent outlets are "discriminated against," both in terms of access to press conferences and government officials and in advertisement revenue: government actors strategically leverage these resources to accumulate media and information dominancy. As Hungarian MP Marton said,

They [Fidesz] have a very tight control over what news gets to whom. And the key factor here is advertisement. So that sometimes happens that they just simply buy off or close newspapers, or whatever radio channels, or take away different frequency, which is a very aggressive move.

Here, Marton speaks to the array of media capture techniques being deployed in the Hungarian media landscape, ranging from outright ownership of private media by government-friendly businesses to restriction of access to resources. Interviewees saw government advertising as a crucial means of survival that could not be turned down. According to interviewee Mariem*, after the Jasmine Revolution and the transition to democracy in Tunisia, "journalists working for the public service media . . . tried their best at the beginning, but then, because of the pressure that was put to them . . . of course, [led to] like backsliding and regression."⁸ Since these governments have realized their economic dominance over the media landscape, said Tunisian lawyer Asma, they feel increasingly emboldened to "say what they want," even disseminating obvious propaganda through mainstream media. Mariem and Asma speak here to Stiglitz (2017)'s notion of "cognitive capture," wherein the media becomes a mouthpiece that ventriloquizes the government's status quo rather than a journalistic watchdog—the function of media in healthy democracies (Kovach & Rosenstiel, 2021). According to Bolivian journalist Rudolpho, mainstream media spread government propaganda because media professionals and journalists must appease their government funders in order to secure the ad funding critical to the outlets' economic survival. As Turkish former diplomat-turned-political-analyst Sinan said, "these

hosts of different structural barriers that have come to, you know, poison the media landscape.”

Digital Adoption and Transition

In the four countries we studied, political elites all had different reasons for expanding from offline advertising to social media. Many moved to social media based on examples of true online democratic participation; for example, in Tunisia, governments shifted to online advertising after learning of the mobilization potential of online activism of the 2011 Jasmine Revolution (Breuer et al., 2015), and Turkey learned the same lesson from the 2013 Gezi Protests (Demirhan, 2014). Or on a smaller scale, in Hungary, policy analyst Patrik points out that the cooperation of opposition parties to win an important mayoral election in Budapest in 2019 kickstarted a renovated and aggressive social media investment from Fidesz (Szabó, 2022). In Bolivia, magazine editor and director Michelle pointed to growing polarization following the grassroots 2006 electoral victory of Evo Morales and his MAS party that revealed opportunities to digitally mobilize the party (Sánchez-Sibony, 2021). As the government shifted selective advertising resources to “friendly” media outlets, newspapers closed and increasing media bias increased political polarization, further encouraging this transition to digital advertising.

Now, after these turning points, the governments of these countries recognize the importance of social media and its advertising capabilities. However, they did not always see it this way, explained Turkish journalist Murat*; according to Hungarian journalist Viktoria, it took time and learning for governments to become “absolutely professional” in social media strategies. Says Hungarian journalist Istvan*, “they [Fidesz] became very professional and spend a lot of money on one hand, and they understood how these platforms work.” In Tunisia, several interviewees, including Nour*, Imen, Sarah, and Sana*, told us that now, nearly all political communication from President Saied occurs on his Facebook Page; Damian* said, “The official voice of the Tunisian government is usually through Facebook.” Elite political actors now spread their primary political messaging through the lowered guardrails of social media.

Goals of Digital Advertising

Interviewees offered several explanations as to why political elites are using social media and social media advertising to spread their propagandistic messaging. One is that governments are attempting to reach new voters, particularly younger people. As Turkish journalist Fusun argued, voters for the ruling Justice and Development Party (AKP) are generally older and not using digital media as frequently, and so in theory, “They [AKP] have no need to make propaganda over the Internet.” Yet Gurkan and political analyst Lorant argue that AKP and other leading parties are spending advertising and campaign money on social media platforms precisely *because* of this dilemma: they are trying to reach younger audiences and court their votes. The “digital architecture” (Bossetta, 2018) of social media platforms allows for hyper-personalization of non-consensual OPC through microtargeting—a strategic advantage only available on digital platforms, and one that is key for hard-to-reach audiences such as younger voters. As Hungarian political and media analyst Lorant said, “. . . the Hungarian youth, they are not interested in public politics . . . So it’s very hard

for them [Fidesz] to reach this younger group.” These younger potential voters are active on platforms like Instagram or TikTok, and so, as Yasmine* in Tunisia points out, it makes sense to use these platforms to target them.

Indeed, it is these microtargeting abilities that distinguish digital advertisements from organic social media tactics: political advertisers can force their ads to appear on the feeds or pages of targeted younger users, whether those users follow that political actor or not. Users have limited options to customize advertising preferences for their feeds. Advertisers have much greater informational curation power (an incentive from the platforms to keep them spending advertising dollars; Vaidhyanathan, 2022). This enables governments to practice “flooding”: overpopulating an information environment (such as social media feeds) with politically biased or false information—i.e., propaganda and disinformation (Cirone & Hobbs, 2023). When ad budgets are essentially unlimited, flooding is an easy way for political actors to spread non-consensual OPC. Marton argued that in Hungary, flooding is used to encourage political apathy and news avoidance, saying, “What they do is that they do not necessarily want to convince you . . . their goal is that you don’t see anything else. And you just kind of get tired of it.” Hungarian media analyst Agnes commented that it’s not just that Fidesz advertisements are “everywhere,” but that the content of the advertisement is coordinated to “repeat the same message everywhere.” Hungarian journalist Viktoria discussed the coordination of campaigns on traditional and digital media, saying, “For them [Fidesz], I think it’s important to have all segments of the media . . . It’s everything and also it’s all connected.” When Hungarian interviewees discussed flooding, they referred to the flooding of the *entire* media zone, including social media feeds—Facebook, YouTube—and traditional media (state, captured, and private TV, radio, print). This constant iteration of messaging across digital and traditional platforms is a form of Stiglitz’s (2017) “cognitive capture,” in which media reflects (and thus reinforces and empowers) the government’s status quo. The acceleration and omnipresence of this capture is afforded in large part by social media advertising.

Barriers to Entry

While digital advertising in Bolivia, Hungary, Tunisia, and Turkey seems as though it would be democratizing—it allows independent political advertising to exist outside of a highly polarized traditional media environment; it lacks the infrastructural barriers of traditional advertising; and it allows a plurality of political voices and opinions to emerge—there is, according to interviewees, a central dilemma that thwarts its potential democratizing power: majority political powers have money and resources that smaller, opposition parties do not. As the Hungarian journalist Máté put it, “They [opposition] have no chance in competing on the advertisement side of things.” Political elites and allies continuously adapt to and adopt new technologies (Trauthig et al., 2023; Guriev & Treisman, 2019), and digital political advertising is a new playground for governments who seek to control political narratives, allowing them to spread propaganda at a much larger scale.

Social media advertising is certainly used by smaller parties and down-ballot candidates (Fowler et al., 2021), but the quantity and diversity of advertisements needed to reach varied audiences is a challenge for resource-poor actors. For example, Bolivian political and legal adviser Carolina said that the opposition party in Bolivia sees social media as a key communicative asset for less-resourced political figures, but that social media *advertising*

is simply not something that she can invest significant time or money in. Similarly, in Turkey, opposition parties debate whether spending the money on social media advertising is worth it; according to journalist and analyst Gurkan, some suggest that in-person campaigning is more strategic; while social media platforms do offer performance metrics for advertisers to see user engagement, it is difficult to know whether social media advertising led changed behavior at the ballot box (Dommett & Power, 2019). For these reasons, social media advertising is less likely to level the playing field and more likely to accelerate and grow the reach of political elites, who can mount year-round non-consensual OPC campaigns that aim to reinforce the status quo of political power and messaging while maintaining a false appearance of democratic participation.

The financial infrastructure of social media advertising also favors monopolistic actors who have what Sinan called “deep pockets,” thus reducing pluralistic expression (a democratic pillar). Social media advertisement placements are traditionally decided through real-time digital auctions that take places in mere milliseconds. The ad publisher—for example, Facebook—puts placements (designated site space for ads) up for bid to advertisers. Typically, bid prices are dynamically determined based on how optimal each ad opportunity is. The bidding system favors the highest price, and so well-resourced advertisers may *consistently* bid high for and *consistently* win advertising spots. As Hungarian journalist and media professional Peter said, “It’s not just that they sort of carpet bomb Facebook [with ads] . . . [it’s] very hard to compete, unless you have sort of similar resources, and no one in Hungary has similar resources.” Here, Peter speaks to what Nechushtai (2018) calls “infrastructural capture” of social media platforms. According to Peter, political actors must opt into social media campaigning to compete with the larger parties, but advertising on these platforms is an expensive proposition that smaller organizations (both media and political) struggle to fully engage with. It is crucial to have a presence on the platforms, but optimizing for all platform functions is a privilege that can only be exercised with extensive financial resources.

Domestic and Foreign Coordination

Using social media advertising for non-consensual OPC presents several unique opportunities for political elites and allies engaging in strategic democratic weakening: these groups can engage in coordinated collaborations (both direct and indirect) between political elites and their supporters, and between domestic and foreign actors—such as members of a country’s diaspora community or regional or foreign allies of a particular government or party. A primary theme that emerged from our interviews was that these coordination efforts were frequently in the service of circumventing campaign finance limits on advertising spend. There are rules in place in all four of the countries we studied that regulate media advertising during political campaigning to varying degrees. Yet, these existent caps or requirements can be circumvented by having other actors pay for ads. As Bolivian political consultant Laura said, “The interesting thing is that these advertising and social media are paid, like, for accounts outside Bolivia . . . I don’t know who is like paying this advertising because they’re fake accounts . . . But they have followers, and they have the money.” When regulators or critics point out the propaganda being pushed in these coordinated ad campaigns, political elites who use these loopholes in advertising spend may claim that the fake accounts are not “official” party accounts—an attempt to hide

behind these advertising platforms' weaknesses to defend their political legitimacy and avoid accountability. This shield is unfortunately effective.

Similarly, in Tunisia, the greater Tunisian diaspora community is often tapped to supply political ads that evade campaign finance rules. According to Elizia, a reporter in Tunisia, campaign advertising limits are circumvented by Tunisians living in the diaspora who support President Saied, some of whom are recruited and some of whom volunteer: "I mean, it's still illegal, it's just that nobody can track it . . . And the thing is it might not be you paying for it, you know it might be a supporter paying for it . . . and there are plenty of supporters in the diaspora who think Saied is fantastic."

Coordination is also used to suppress unwanted speech: parties buy ad space on social media to drive harassment campaigns targeting opposition party candidates or supporters. Coordinated trolling efforts are detrimental to the democratic pillar of safe and open public spheres of political discussion. As we have seen, in competitive authoritarian countries, political elites have the economic leverage to dominate both digital ad spaces and traditional media spaces, and their coordinated harassment efforts span both realms, making these campaigns especially damaging. As Turkish political communicator Tarik explained, organized trolling networks are designed to "make people hopeless," discouraging them enough to keep them from participating in "politics anymore." Hungarian journalist Szabolcs described these coordinated harassment efforts across traditional and digital advertising mediums as "smear campaigns" that force people to stop and think, "Am I stupid enough to put the target on myself?" These political elites and their allies use coordination tactics through advertising to dissuade current and future participation in public life—a pillar of democratic society.

Monitoring and Transparency

Meta and Google have now implemented some transparency measures allowing social media advertising sources and spend, as well as ad libraries, to be monitored by news organizations and fact checkers; Hungarian journalist Zsófia noted that her news organization has started to use these new resources to "tackle the disinformation in the political paid ads on social media" around election seasons. Both Turkish and Tunisian interviewees pointed out that ad library data reveals the enormous amounts of money being spent on social media platforms by large, well-resourced political parties. But these transparency efforts only go so far, for as Elizia and Laura discussed above, funding sources may be hidden or outsourced to a third party.

Tunisian interviewees also spoke to another common social media practice for evading transparency measures: flipping the administrators of Facebook Pages and Groups in order to flip them to political elites' purposes. Previously, nonpolitical Facebook groups—for example, groups on fashion, cooking, or travel—may be flipped into explicitly partisan political groups, with political ads, propaganda posts, and direct political messaging to group members. Similarly, an admin swap can flip an existing politically partisan Facebook group into a political mouthpiece for an opposing party. As journalist and French parliamentary collaborator Amine in Tunisia said, "in the last 10 years, you've seen that those Facebook pages have been sold, like, to seven, eight different political lines." Tunisian researcher and lawyer Asma tried to identify who was behind some of these takeovers, looking at advertisement sources for the pages and trying to locate them within close-knit

political Tunisian networks. However, she noted that the process is not easy, saying, “I mean there is tools to check . . . from where something is financed. But it’s not that easy and people are not stupid . . . no one is going to use a French card or bank account.” Analysts digging into published ad libraries can only go so far to confront and expose these propagandistic narratives and sources of funding.

Conclusion

This study expands upon the existing conceptualizations of how propaganda contributes to democratic weakening (Guriev & Treisman, 2019) by showing how traditional and digital media systems may be strategically abused to consolidate power: advertising—and particularly social media advertising—is being coopted to create new forms of capture of both media and information architecture. Our findings highlight how media dominance may be obtained not only through force but through economic leverage. We show that this capture contributes to the spread of pro-government propaganda, which strategically weakens independent media, and, in turn, the plurality of voices heard. We also described both the opportunities and challenges social media advertising presents for elites and allies, who can afford to deploy hyper-personalized OPC information campaigns; for example, one Turkey interviewee discussed micro-targeting parameters to reach younger users in the hopes of courting their vote (Barbu, 2014), and a Hungarian interviewee described flooding the social media zone with a repetitive narrative to drown out a plurality of political voices (Cirone & Hobbs, 2023) and induce democratic fatigue among voters.

Our findings also speak to the advertising finance mechanisms that allow political elites to dictate propagandistic messaging in novel ways, as when Bolivian and Tunisian interviewees reported domestic and foreign coordination to circumvent advertising caps and Hungarian interviewees discussed using paid ad placements to intensify harassment campaigns (Woolley, 2023; Zannettou et al., 2019). We conclude that in these four competitive authoritarian countries, political elites and allies are weaponizing advertising mechanisms, using them as a shield to hide the government’s lack of transparency, a weapon to harass critics, and a strategy to weaken democratic pillars such as freedom of the press, plurality of citizen voices, and a free and fair marketplace of ideas. These countries used advertising tactics to suppress the plurality of political voices within dissenting media; to reduce political participation by manipulating feeds (“flooding”) and targeting opponents with harassment; and to circumvent the legal guardrails around campaign advertising caps by using indirect foreign and domestic proxies.

Our findings here bring forward several directions for future research. First, our findings highlight how easy it is to evade social media advertising policies. We selected the weakening democracies in this study in part because they all have notable policies governing funding, sovereignty, and disinformation (Lim & Bradshaw, 2023; Moravec & Folk, 2023; Reuters, 2022; Zaghdoudi, 2023). However, we discovered that they have all found ways around their own policies, allowing them to retain a veneer of democratic legitimacy while in fact capturing the media. For example, all of these countries have a version of legal spending caps on political campaign advertisements to varying degrees, but we heard how political elites and their allies strategically circumvented these policies by outsourcing advertising costs to direct and indirect online proxies (direct proxies are hired by political elites to create fake social media accounts to generate political advertising; indirect proxies—which were

more commonly mentioned in our dataset—were usually either hired marketing firms or consultants placing ads or grassroots actors in domestic and diasporic communities creating fake accounts and/or paying for advertisements). These direct and indirect measures avoid spending caps on advertising and obfuscate the source of the advertisements. Future research could expand upon how technology and political actors can better prepare for and prevent these deceitful propagandistic tactics, while also examining the technical and political obstacles to implementing such preventative measures in various local contexts.

Our findings also indicate that real-time bidding for ad placement creates an unlevel playing field: political elites with greater resources can buy more and better ad placements. This finding was strongest in the Hungarian media and political landscape, but interviewees in Bolivia, Tunisia, and Turkey also noted that offline political inequalities were reproduced in digital realms. Future research could look at these platforms' bidding systems and suggest internal guardrails that could prevent any single advertiser from gaining dominance within a given platform. However, as noted earlier, monitoring and measuring advertising dominance is complicated and may be hindered by the use (whether explicit or covert) of advertiser proxies.

In summary, we suggest that future researchers, technologists, and policymakers should continue to examine how social media advertising accelerates information control in weakening democracies and competitive authoritarian states, leading to new forms of capture for both information and infrastructure; these forms of capture spread from the digital realm to the realm of traditional media, allowing these political elites and allies to undermine the democratic pillars of free press, free and fair elections, and freedom of expression while retaining the veneer of democratic legitimacy.

Notes

1. Substituted for anonymization.
2. Bolivia (16), Hungary (16), Tunisia (11), Turkey (17).
3. See [Appendix B](#) for Interviewee Details
4. See [Appendix B](#)
5. The majority of interviews followed this criterion with the exception of two interviewees that worked for a pro-government newspaper and think tank.
6. Naturally, interviewee responses drew on examples and speculations stemming from past or upcoming notable elections, including the 2019 and 2020 General Elections and the upcoming 2025 General Election in Bolivia; the 2019 Budapest mayoral election, 2022 Presidential Election, and then-upcoming 2024 European Parliament Elections in Hungary; the 2019 Presidential Election, 2021 power-grab, and then-upcoming 2024 Presidential Election in Tunisia; and the 2023 Presidential Election and 2024 Local Elections in Turkey.
7. This study received IRB approval on XXX from XXX (anonymized).
8. *Given pseudonym.

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Data Availability Statement

The participants of this study did not give written consent for their data to be shared publicly, so due to the sensitive nature of the research supporting data is not available.

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Appendices

Appendix A: Case Selection Extended

Regional Diversity

We approach these research questions through a qualitative, comparative study of four countries discussed in literature and media as weakening democracies and competitive authoritarian regimes: Bolivia, Tunisia, Turkey, and Hungary (Esen & Gumuscu, 2025; Riaz & Rana, 2024; Rupnik, 2022; Yerkes & Henneberg, 2024). These countries were selected to shed light on viewpoints and nuances of political information flows across disparate geographies. We take this international comparative approach for two reasons: first, to highlight the fact that democratic weakening into competitive authoritarianism is a global trend, not something happening only in a particular place or region, and second, to highlight the variations and similarities in the global phenomenon of advertising being used to spread propaganda and disinformation on and offline.

Independence of Media

This paper focuses on how political elites and allies weaponize the existing media and advertising landscape to serve pro-government propagandistic purposes. These countries were chosen specifically because each has a weakening independent media landscape. This is a key condition for country comparison selection, because the independence of a country's media landscape has a direct impact on the creation, spread, and consumption of propaganda (Woolley, 2023; Macleod, 2019). According to Freedom House Reports of 2024, on the question of whether there are “free and independent media,” Turkey scores 1 out of a possible 4, and Tunisia, Hungary, and Bolivia all score 2 out of 4 (Freedom House, 2024a, 2024c, 2024d, 2024b). The Reporters Without Borders “World Press Freedom” Index also indicates the waning freedom of the press in these countries: not only did all these countries receive low scores for 2024 (Bolivia 48.8/100, Hungary 62/100, Tunisia 49.97/100, and Turkey 31.6/100), but all of them scored lower in 2024 than they had in 2023.

Elections and “Strongmen”

Over the last two decades, notable elections in all four countries either accelerated or were the result of the consolidation and economic weaponization of traditional and digital media industries—in other words, the weakening of the democratic pillar of a free and independent press. In Hungary, after the 2010 election of Fidesz Prime Minister Viktor Orbán, Hungary's independent news environment dwindled, and government critics are now overwhelmingly harassed into silence (Political Capital, 2022); other democratic institutions and processes also weakened, including the judicial system (European Parliament, 2022). In Bolivia, under the presidency of Evo Morales (2006-2019) and the continued empowerment of his Movimiento al Socialismo (MAS) party (2020-present), the democratic pillar of free and fair elections was compromised in two ways: first, by persistent legal challenges to presidential term limits (Doyle, 2019), and second, by escalating polarization along ethnic lines (intensified by traditional and digital media), which led to on- and offline violence (Global Centre for Pluralism, 2021). In Turkey, President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan's 2014 election ignited a political trend toward authoritarianism, with government critics and dissenters (including journalists, lawyers, activists, and academics) frequently targeted and detained (Kirby, 2023). Lastly, in Tunisia, the 2021 power-grab of elected President Kais Saied curbed political pluralism, with challengers and journalists imprisoned (Bouazza, 2024) and vulnerable groups—especially sub-Saharan Africans—treated as political scapegoats and targeted with violent and racist rhetoric (Blaise, 2023).

“Anti-Fake News” Laws

In all four of these countries, political elites and allies have deployed their own versions of laws supposedly intended to fight “fake news” that, in actual practice, curb freedom of speech and expression. These laws allow for the arrest of journalists who express dissent and large fines for social media companies that do not remove anti-government content (Reuters, 2022; Zaghdoudi, 2023). Tunisia’s Decree Law No. 54, issued in 2022, uses “vague” and “broad” language to prescribe severe punishments—including lengthy prison sentences—for those who spread false news or rumors (Zaghdoudi, 2023). Its implementation has emboldened the prosecution of government critics; including journalists, lawyers, activists, students, and more (Tunis, 2024). Turkey’s “disinformation law,” issued in 2022, is similar: it prescribes prison sentences for the vaguely phrased crime of spreading “false or misleading information” (Reuters, 2022), and has been used to prosecute critical voices (2023). Bolivia passed a similar measure criminalizing the spread of misinformation in 2020 during the COVID-19 crisis; after immense backlash, the law was annulled by a non-MAS interim President (Lim & Bradshaw, 2023). However, there is currently a tense MAS leadership contest for the 2025 elections (Sivak & Molina, 2024), setting the stage for increased propaganda and disinformation online. In addition to “fake news” laws, several of these countries have recently introduced “sovereignty laws” targeting critical voices that rely on foreign funding: Hungary’s Sovereign Defense Authority Law, adopted in 2023 (Moravec & Folk, 2023) and Turkey’s Foreign Influence Law, proposed in 2024 (Buyuk, 2024). These laws have received backlash from media and human rights organizations. Both the anti-fake news laws and the sovereignty laws are an important contributor to country selection, for they indicate that political elites and allies are selectively controlling the diffusion of information.

Independence & Revolution

These four countries all have a history of colonialism and subsequent revolution and independence movements, which shaped the tactics and techniques of propaganda distribution they use today. Turkey’s independence from the Ottoman Empire in the early 20th century led to the creation of national infrastructure that was grounded in leader Mustafa Kemal Atatürk’s’ secular, European-centric outlook (The Economist, 2023). Turkey’s current President Erdoğan has both rebuked and reimagined Atatürk’s nationalistic legacy in Turkey by selectively downplaying Atatürk’s secular legacy: he highlights the former independence leader’s great nationalistic and militaristic achievements while restructuring religion (Islam) into public life (Coşkun, 2023). Erdoğan uses the nationalistic narratives surrounding Atatürk to further polarize political debate and consolidate political power (ibid). In Bolivia, political life is deeply shaped by the country’s sixteenth-century conquest by Spain, and its nineteenth-century war for independence, both of which left deep-seeded ethnic tensions between indigenous and non-indigenous Bolivians (Crabtree, 2017). Indigenous communities had long been marginalized in public and political spaces in Bolivia, and Evo Morales’ successful electoral bid as the first indigenous President was a watershed moment in the country’s political history (ibid). However, once in power, Morales adopted populist rhetoric and propaganda, further intensifying a public already polarized between the “conservative right versus ‘the people,’ whites/mestizos versus the indigenous,” (McKay & Colque, 2021, p.8). In Tunisia, the mid-twentieth-century movement for independence from French rule and the 2011 Jasmine Revolution both shaped current societal and political discourse (Perkins, 2014). Current President Kais Saied campaigned in 2019 as a political independent that promised to fix persistent economic issues and political corruption—legacies of French colonization and the 1987 rise to power of autocrat Ben Ali, who staged a coup shortly after independence (ibid, Foroudi, 2019). However, President Saied has continued Ben Ali’s autocratic legacy with his 2021 power grab, which removed structural barriers of governance in order to centralize and boost presidential power (Yerkes & Alhomoud, 2022). Saied uses propagandistic narratives of nationalism and independence from foreign actors, and he engages in targeted attacks against a scapegoated Sub-Saharan African immigrant population (Blaise, 2023). Finally, Hungary’s independence from Soviet rule in the late twentieth century created a weakly structured media

market that took decades of regulatory attention to address (Kovács et al., 2021). After an unsuccessful run for president in 2002 (a loss that he attributed to lack of media control; Vojvodic-Medic, n.d.), current President Orbán turned toward the ownership and consolidation of the Hungarian media market after his successful 2010 election (Kovács et al., 2021).

Appendix B: Interviewee Details

Details for interviewees: Bolivia (16), Hungary (16), Tunisia (11), Turkey (17). Recruiting interviewees for Tunisia was especially difficult due to increased pressure and surveillance by Tunisian President Kais Saied and the rising threat of politically motivated punishment, including imprisonment (Bouazza, 2024; Zaghdoudi, 2023).

Interviewee Details

Table B1. Interviewee name, country, profession and pronoun.

Name	Country	Profession	Pronouns
Adrián	Bolivia	Journalist and Director of the Proyecto Desconfío	He/Him
Carolina	Bolivia	Legal Aid to Senator Andrea Barrientos (opposition party Comunidad Ciudadana)	She/Her
Cristian	Bolivia	Executive Director Internet Bolivia	He/Him
Eliana	Bolivia	Internet Activist at Internet Bolivia	She/Her
Fabiola	Bolivia	Freelance Journalist	She/Her
Isabel	Bolivia	Freelance Journalist	She/Her
Jan	Bolivia	Director and Representative of Friedrich Ebert Stiftung in Bolivia	He/Him
Laura	Bolivia	Strategy Manager in Vice Ministry of Communication	She/Her
María	Bolivia	Former Head of Bolivia Verifica and stringer New York Times	She/Her
Miajil	Bolivia	Journalist and Editorial Director of Muy Waso	He/Him
Michelle	Bolivia	Journalist and Operational Director of Muy Waso	She/Her
Rafael	Bolivia	Sociologist and Communication Consultant	He/Him
Ramiro	Bolivia	Human Rights Lawyer and Director of Construir Foundation	He/Him
Renan	Bolivia	Executive Director of Fundación para el Periodismo (FPP)	He/Him
Robert	Bolivia	Freelance Journalist and Author	He/Him
Rodolfo	Bolivia	Freelance Journalist and Educator	He/Him
Agnes	Hungary	Economist and co-founder of Mertek Media Monitor	She/Her
Bánk	Hungary	Deputy Director, Director of Political Analysis, Nézőpont Institute	He/Him
Dániel	Hungary	Director, Political Freedoms Project at Hungarian Civil Liberties Union	He/Him
Istvan*	Hungary	Journalist	He/Him
Konrad	Hungary	Researcher at Center for Media Pluralism and Media Freedom, European University Institute	He/Him
Lóránt	Hungary	Geopolitical Analyst at Political Capital	He/Him
Márton	Hungary	Freelance Journalist	He/Him
Márton	Hungary	Member of the National Assembly of Hungary, Momentum Movement	He/Him
Máté	Hungary	Journalist and Fact Checker at Telex.hu	He/Him
Patrik	Hungary	Research Fellow at Center for Democracy & Resilience	He/Him
Peter	Hungary	Director at Funds4Media and Consultant at mdiforg	He/Him
Szabolcs	Hungary	Editor at VSquare_Project and Journalist at direkt36	He/Him
Veronika	Hungary	Director at Dennik N and Educator	She/Her
Viktória	Hungary	Journalist at HVG	She/Her
Zoltán	Hungary	Editor-in-Chief and Manager of Átlátszó Erdély	He/Him
Zsófia	Hungary	Journalist at Lakmusz	She/Her
Amine	Tunisia	Journalist and Parliamentary Collaborator—LFI	He/Him
Amir*	Tunisia	Political Marketer and Consultant	He/Him
Asma	Tunisia	Anthropologist and Lawyer, International Detention Coalition	She/Her
Damian*	Tunisia	Policy Analyst	He/Him
Elizia	Tunisia	Freelance Journalist	She/Her
Imen	Tunisia	Freelance Journalist	She/Her
Mariem*	Tunisia	Human Rights Think Tank	She/Her
Nour*	Tunisia	Researcher at Non-Profit Organization	She/Her
Sana*	Tunisia	Policy Analyst	She/Her

(Continued)

Table B1. (Continued).

Name	Country	Profession	Pronouns
Sarah	Tunisia	Senior Fellow, Carnegie Endowment for International Peace	She/Her
Yasmine*	Tunisia	Political Digital Analyst	She/Her
Afet*	Turkey	Journalist	He/Him
Ceren	Turkey	Freelance Journalist and Educator	She/Her
Demir*	Turkey	Fact Checker	He/Him
Ela*	Turkey	Journalist	She/Her
Emre	Turkey	Director of Teyit	He/Him
Eren*	Turkey	Journalist and Digital Rights Researcher	He/Him
Fusun	Turkey	Journalist and IT Specialist	She/Her
Gurkan	Turkey	Monitoring Officer at European Centre for Press & Media Freedom	He/Him
Koray	Turkey	Co-Founder Doğruluk Payı	He/Him
Metin	Turkey	Freelance Journalist & Photojournalist	He/Him
Muharrem	Turkey	Freelance Journalist and Educator	He/Him
Murat*	Turkey	Journalist	He/Him
Ozgur	Turkey	Freelance journalist and Committee to Protect Journalist's Turkey representative	He/Him
Ragip	Turkey	Turkey Bureau Chief, Middle East Eye	He/Him
Sarphan	Turkey	Founder of NewsLabTurkey	He/Him
Sinan	Turkey	Former Diplomat and Director of EdamOrg	He/Him
Tarik	Turkey	Communications Consultant	He/Him

*Pseudonym

Table B2. Expanded interview questionnaire.

Interview Format	In Depth
Interview Duration	45 minutes to 1 hour
Interview Setting	Zoom (video & audio recorded & transcribed upon permission)
Interview Language	All Zoom interviews were conducted by the research team in English, with the exception of three Turkish interviews that were first conducted in Turkish by a member of the research team and later transcribed into English with the aid of generative AI translation services.
Questionnaire Format	Semi-Structured (Set Questions + Follow Ups)
Selected Example Questions	As we mentioned earlier, one of the reasons we are studying <u>COUNTRY X</u> is because of its experience with democratic weakening. As media researchers, we are particularly interested in how the media and its freedom and independence is affected by this backsliding. Can you tell us about how the media landscape has perhaps changed over the past several years and how strong is the independent media landscape today? How does government advertising play a role in independent media's sustainability? Both traditional (offline) and digital (online)? How do political actors use social media to spread propaganda or disinformation campaigns? Specifically, how have you seen social media advertising used for these propaganda purposes? In your perspective, why are political actors in <u>COUNTRY X</u> turning to social media advertising for spreading propaganda? In your perspective, what are the democratic implications in <u>COUNTRY X</u> because of these propaganda through advertising tactics?